

Un'tane Tokef

241a

Version 2

Nissan Blumenthal
Arr. Stuart Izon

Un'tane Tokef is the central piyut of the High Holy Days mussaf repetition, and contains some of the most dramatic poetry in the entire liturgy. It is a symphony in four movements, the first of which details the high drama of the day of judgement where even the angels in heaven tremble in fear. The following section depicts a gentler image of God as shepherd of His flock. Though a well-known legend from the Ohr Zarua recounts that this prayer was composed by Rabbi Amnon of Mainz, this is certainly inaccurate since fragments have been found in the Cairo Geniza, but it may be responsible for its transmission and how it gained universal acceptance in the liturgy.

*Nissan Blumenthal's composition must surely rate as one of the finest classic settings of Un'tane Tokef, with its beautiful romantic themes, stirring solo sections and elegant harmony. In many congregations, Un'tane Tokef is a patchwork of different compositions, but often includes parts of this setting. The opening section is very clearly modelled on the beginning of Felix Mendelssohn's *Warum toben die Heiden* (Psalm 2), a work which Blumenthal undoubtedly knew and creatively refashioned for the High Holy Day text. After some original motivic material, Mendelssohn's theme returns to close out the first paragraph.*

*The second section, beginning at K'vakarat, is less well known. Blumenthal's pastoral setting evokes the kindly shepherd in the meadow, and begins with a direct quotation from the "Ranz des vaches" section of Rossini's *William Tell* Overture.*

Rather than diminishing the piece, these borrowings illuminate the musical world in which Blumenthal worked and the artistry with which he shaped familiar Romantic idioms into a uniquely moving liturgical setting. Blumenthal was a contemporary of both Mendelssohn and Rossini. He was chief chazzan at Odessa's choral Broder Synagogue, and is cited by many as the first "khor hazzan" in eastern Europe. He viewed the incorporation of references from classical repertoire as artistically beneficial to chazzanut – if they were appropriate to the text and could fit into the proper prayer modes, not as unconsidered dilutions for the sake of popularity.

Andante moderato

Melody

Alto

Tenor

Bass

U - n' - ta - ne to - kef u - n' - ta - ne to - kef k' - du -

U - n' - ta - ne to - kef to - kef k' - du -

U - n' - ta - ne to - kef u - n' - ta - ne to - kef k' - du -

U - n' - ta - ne to - kef to - kef k' - du -

5

M
A

-shat_ ha - yom_ k' - du - shat ha - yom

-shat_ ha - yom_ k' - du - shat_ ha - yom

T
B

-shat_ ha - yom_ k' - du - shat ha - yom

-shat_ ha - yom_ k' - du - shat ha - yom

9

C.

f

Ki hu no-ra v' - a - yom u - vo ti-na-sei mal-chu-

M
A

sfz *ff* *mf* *f*

Ah ki hu no - ra v' - a - yom Ah u -

T
B

13

Meno mosso

C.

-te - cha *mp* v' - yi - kon b' - che - sed v' - yi kon b' - che - sed

M
A

p

-vo ti-na-sei mal-chu - te - cha Ah

T
B

Tempo primo

17

C.

8

ki - se - cha

M

A

8

ki - se cha v' - tei -

T

B

mp

v' - tei - shev a - lav v' - tei -

21

M

A

8

-shev a - lav be - e - met v' - tei -

T

B

-shev a - lav be - e - met v' - tei - shev a - lav v' - tei -

25

M

A

8

-shev a - lav be - e - met

T

B

-shev a - lav be - e - met

29

C. *f*
E - met_____ ki a - ta hu da - yan u - mo -

M
A *fp*
Ah_____

T
B

33

C. *mp*
-chi - - ach v'-yo-dei - a va - eid v'-cho - teiv_____

M
A *mp*
Ah_____ v'-cho-

T
B

37

C. v'-cho - teim_____ v'-so - fer_____ u - mo -

M
A -teiv v'-cho-teim v'-so - fer

T
B

42

C.

8

2

7

pp

- ne

v' - tiz - kor kol ha-nish-ka - chot

M

A

8

u - mo - ne

T

B

46

Ritenuato

M

A

8

p

V' - tif - tach et se - fer ha - zich - ro - not u - mei - ei

T

B

50

M

A

8

mf

p

lav yi - ka - rei v'-cho - tam yad kol a - dam bo

T

B

Risoluto

54

C. *ff* U - va - sho - far ga - dol yi - ta - ka *mp* v' -

M A *f* Oo yi - ta - ka

T B

Ritenuto

59

C. *p* -kol d' - ma - ma da - ka yi - sha - ma

M A *p* Ah yi - sha - ma

T B

Con fuoco

64

C. *f* v' -

M A *f* U - ma - la - chim yei - cha - fei - zun v' - chil u - ra - da yo - chei - zun

T B U - ma - la - chim - yei - cha - fei u - ma - la - chim - yei - cha fei chil u - ra - da yo - chei - zun

68

72

C. 
-yo - m' - ru

M
A 
v' - yo - m' - ru

T
B 
hi - nei yom ha - din

ff *mp*

76

C. *8*
-kod al tz'-va ma - rom ba - - din ki lo yiz-ku v'-ei -

M
A *8*
p Ah ba - - din *p* Ah

T
B *8*

Tempo Primo

81

C.

M

A

T

B

85

M

A

T

B

89

M

A

T

B

Pastorale

Chazzan

8

mp K' - va - - - ka - rat

Baritone

mp k' - va - ka -

Melody Alto

8

pp Ah

Tenor Bass

5

C.

ma - a - vir tzo - no

B.

-rat ro - e ed - ro

M A

8

Ah

T B

10

C.

B.

ta - chat shiv - to

ma - a - vir tzo - no ta - chat shiv - to

M
A

Ah

T
B

15 **Più mosso**

M
A

mp *mf* *f*

ken ta - a - vir v' - tis - por v' - tim - ne v' - tif - kod

T
B

20

M
A

mp *mf*

ne - fesh kol chai v'-tach - toch kitz - va l' - chol b' - ri -

T
B

26

M
A

8

f *mf*

-a v' - tich - tov et g' - zar di - nam

T
B

31

M
A

8

mf

et g' - zar di - nam

T
B

mp *mp*

et g' - zar di - nam et g' - zar di -

37

M
A

8

mp *p* *pp*

et g' - zar di - nam g' - zar di - nam

T
B

-nam di - nam g' - zar di - nam

Adagio